

LITTLE STICKY TOFFEE PUDDINGS with PECAN TOFFEE SAUCE

SERVES 8 PEOPLE

This is as wicked as it sounds. A truly delectable combination of flavours and textures which are light and melt in the mouth (see page 158). I would choose this as a Christmas or New Year dinner-party dessert, as the puddings freeze well and are no trouble to re-heat.

FOR THE PUDDINGS:

3 oz (75 g) butter, at room temperature	4 oz (110 g) butter
5 oz (150 g) caster sugar	6 tablespoons double cream
2 eggs, size 2, beaten	1 oz (25 g) pecan nuts, chopped
6 oz (175 g) self-raising flour, sifted	
6 oz (175 g) stoned dates, chopped	
6 fl oz (175 ml) boiling water	
$\frac{1}{2}$ teaspoon vanilla essence	
2 teaspoons coffee essence	
$\frac{1}{4}$ teaspoon bicarbonate of soda	

TO SERVE:
Chilled pouring cream

You will need eight 6 oz (175 g) metal pudding basins (see page 219) or eight 3 inch (7.5 cm) ramekin dishes, lightly oiled with groundnut oil, a Swiss-roll tin, and a baking sheet.

FOR THE SAUCE:

6 oz (175 g) soft brown sugar

PRE-HEAT THE OVEN TO GAS MARK 4, 350°F (180°C)

Begin by putting the chopped dates in a bowl and pouring boiling water over them. Then add the vanilla, coffee essence and bicarbonate of soda, and leave on one side. Next in a large mixing bowl, cream the butter and sugar together, beating (preferably with an electric hand whisk) until the mixture is pale, light and fluffy. Now gradually add the beaten eggs, a little at a time, beating well after each addition. After that carefully and lightly fold in the sifted flour using a metal spoon, and then you can fold in the date mixture (including the liquid). You'll probably think at this stage that you've done something wrong, because the mixture will look very sloppy, but don't worry: that is perfectly correct and the slackness of the mixture is what makes the pudding so light. Now divide the mixture equally between the eight containers, place them on a baking tray and bake in the centre of the oven for 25 minutes.

When they're cooked, leave them to cool for 5 minutes then, using a cloth to protect your hands, slide a small palette knife around each pudding and turn it out. If they have risen too much you may have to slice a little off the tops so that

they can sit evenly on the plate (see the photograph on page 158). Now place the puddings on a shallow, Swiss roll-type tin. Next make the sauce by combining all the ingredients in a saucepan and heating very gently until the sugar has melted and all the crystals have dissolved.

To serve the puddings: pre-heat the grill to its highest setting, and pour the sauce evenly over the puddings. Place the tin under the grill so the tops of the puddings are about 5 inches (13 cm) from the heat. Knock off any nuts on the top to prevent them browning) and let them heat through for about 8 minutes. What will happen is the tops will become brown and slightly crunchy and the sauce will be hot and bubbling. Serve with chilled pouring cream - and sit back to watch the looks of ecstasy on the faces of your guests.

NOTE: After freezing, de-frost, pour the hot sauce over and re-heat.

OLD ENGLISH PORT WINE JELLY

SERVES 8 PEOPLE

After a rich main course nothing could be nicer and more refreshing to finish off the meal than this cool, light and fragrant jelly.

5 oz (150 g) granulated sugar	3 level tablespoons powdered gelatine
15 fl oz (425 ml) plus 4 tablespoons water	15 fl oz (425 ml) good quality ruby port
1 stick cinnamon	5 fl oz (150 ml) light red wine
4 cloves	Frosted black grapes (see page 165)
1 blade mace	
The thinly pared zest and juice of 1 large lemon	You will need a $1\frac{1}{4}$ pint (750 ml) jelly mould or 8 stemmed glasses.

First place 3 oz (75 g) sugar in a saucepan along with 15 fl oz (425 ml) water and the cinnamon stick, cloves, mace and lemon zest and juice. Cover the pan and bring to the boil, then remove from the heat. Sprinkle in the gelatine, whisk and allow it to dissolve for 15 minutes, whisking again from time to time.

Now strain the spices and zest from the syrup. Then stir the port and wine into it, and at this stage taste it: the flavour should be strong and rather more sweet than you would normally have it - this sweetness lessens once the mixture is chilled. Stir in more sugar if you are sure it needs it and stir until dissolved. Now pour the liquid into the jelly mould or 8 stemmed glasses and leave to set. Serve slightly chilled and topped with frosted black grapes.